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TECH

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■ INTERNET ■ COMPUTERS ■ CONSUMER ELECTRONICS ■ TELECOMMUNICATIONS

Business editor: Dennis Punzel 252-6486 The Capital Times ■ Thursday, Feb. 7, 2002*

WEB SITE OF THE WEEK

Black Facts Online

Just the facts

If you're looking for information on black history, Black Facts Online can help. This unique site was launched in 1997 as a collaboration between Massachusetts-based Inner-City Software and contributing researchers to compile facts.

Found at www.blackfacts.com, the site offers a search that looks up facts per day or by key word. Its founders wanted to make it easy to find interesting and inspiring facts about events impacting people of African descent. You can also sign up for free daily black fact e-mail messages.

The resource is free and available throughout the year for those doing research, seeking information or wanting to learn about black history.

— Lynn Welch

BITS & BYTES

New technology targets staffing challenges

■ Madison's Modern Business Technology Inc. will market and sell two new technology solutions that address the staffing challenges of small and medium businesses.

The Virtual Receptionist performs the duties of a receptionist, greeting customers and gathering general information from them. The product was designed by the Madison firm and Compaq Inc. It detects a visitor's presence and launches an audio greeting inviting the customer to approach a kiosk. When an icon is touched, the kiosk launches a real-time video conferencing session with an employee.

The enCompass is a complete network for up to 50 users. It includes a software package and a server with pre-configured company data such as mail accounts and employee information. The system offers a remote monitoring service for companies who don't have an on-staff technician.

Modern Business Technology is a technology integrator and reseller of networking equipment in business since 1977.

Sonic Foundry buys Media Taxi system

■ Sonic Foundry's Media Services subsidiary has an agreement to buy the Media Taxi asset management system from Digital Savant Inc. for 200,000 shares of stock and $100,000 cash.

Media Taxi is a browser-based media asset management system that streamlines and reduces costs of managing and distributing marketing materials. Launched in 1998, the system stores a large catalog of advertising materials online covering over 50,000 hours of programming information to support entertainment products. It also offers secure access to media assets to service advertising and publicity requirements online.

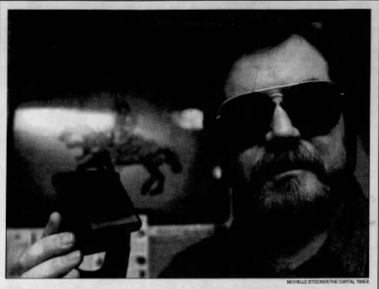
"Our future strategy is based on the inevitable migration of the distribution of entertainment assets from costly and labor intensive handling of physical media to the streamlined and efficient movement of electronic data files," said Ted Lingard, senior vice president and general manager for Sonic Foundry Media Services, formerly MediaSite.

Media Taxi's creator and Digital Savant's CEO Alex Shobet will join Sonic Foundry Media Services Inc. The product will become part of the company's MediaWorks applications.

Madison tech group hosts February session

■ George Dalton, chairman and CEO of Call Solutions and Piserv Inc. founder, will speak at the Feb. 21 meeting of Accelerate Madison. He'll tell the story about building Piserv into a successful business.

The event will be held at the Plano Center, 601 University Ave., beginning at 5 p.m. followed by the main presentation at 6 p.m. Cost for the event is $25, $10 for students. For details and registration, please go to www.acceleratemadison.org.



MICHELLE STOCKER/THE CAPITAL TIMES

Robert Gold of CyberKnight International developed the PDA Pivot after finding his Palm Pilot awkward to handle and use. Launched in November, the product will anchor the consumer products division of Gold's security-focused business.

Pivot man

Area entrepreneur markets PDA accessory

By Lynn Welch
The Capital Times

When you come to think of it, a third hand could be useful in a variety of circumstances.

Among them: writing from a business card, map or report into a handheld computer or personal digital assistant (PDA) without a table.

It's a notion that didn't escape Robert Gold.

"When I got it (the PDA), I realized how awkward it was. It's not ergonomically designed. It's just a box," the Madison product developer explained.

About a month later, Gold put together a gadget using reinforced nylon, a hinge, Velcro and foam to help him use the digital device.

When others started asking him where they could get one, he developed the PDA Pivot.

Late last year, Gold's company, CyberKnight International, officially entered the PDA accessory and peripheral market with the Pivot. The simple Pivot boasts some 18 ways to increase the usefulness of a PDA. Applications range from a desktop or dashboard stand to a hand cradle to a belt or pocket clip.

In launching the Pivot, Gold hopes to anchor CyberKnight's consumer product division and create a stable revenue base for a homeland security business.

"We're focused on making the Pivot a viable product to show we're a viable company with a consumer product division," Gold said. "But our whole thrust will be in the homeland security and safety field and we have a half dozen products in development that address critical needs in that market."

The Pivot — with a patent pending — is the first in a line of PDA accessories CyberKnight plans to unveil. In addition to developing products meant to make PDAs better tools and give users an advantage in various situations, Gold has a number of safety and security tools in the works. They include flood control systems, fire control and suppression systems for high rise buildings, safety stun munitions and emergency shelter and refugee systems.



MICHELLE STOCKER/THE CAPITAL TIMES

The Pivot can be used in a variety of ways, including anchoring a PDA on a computer, desk, table or vehicle dashboard.

While new to the PDA market, Gold has developed a variety of products for the past 25 years under the CyberKnight business name and others. He moved to Madison from Austin, Texas, about a year ago while working as a consultant with Ragovac Corp. developing multiple-use flash lights.

With a background in law enforcement, he invested and brought to market a number of non-lethal weapons, explosive devices and equipment for use by police and military units. They include:

■ The Power Staff, a type of pneumatic club.

■ A line of stun grenades used as distraction devices called Shockwave.

■ SafeCase bulletproof baggage inserts.

Other products include an electronic driver system for flat panel displays, an Internet-based anti-piracy software system and a system to find and recover stolen consumer electronics.

He also wrote, "Eureka!: The Entrepreneurial Inventor's Guide to Developing, Protecting, and Profiting from Your Ideas," published in 1994, and developed a

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Walter Mossberg
PERSONAL TECHNOLOGY



Napster's successors fall short

Ever since the recording industry got the courts to shut down the wildly popular Napster online music service last year, music-loving Internet users have been awaiting the industry's promised next move: a legal service that would take Napster's place.

In recent weeks, the five major record labels finally have launched two online music services meant to redeem that pledge: MusicNet and pressplay. I've been testing both and have come to two conclusions. Neither service is even remotely adequate as a Napster replacement. But one, pressplay, is vastly superior, and offers a ray of hope that the industry may one day give consumers what Napster proved they want.

Napster allowed users to browse through hundreds of thousands of songs and download them for free. The songs could then be used without restriction on PCs and portable players, and burned onto CDs. But Napster was illegal because members didn't own distribution rights.

Some in the industry drew only one lesson from Napster: that consumers want to steal music. But the real lesson was different. For most Napster users, the thrill wasn't that their favorite songs were free, but that they were available in one location, liberated from costly CDs filled with other tracks they never wanted to buy.

MusicNet and pressplay, unfortunately, are designed in a way that reflects the false lesson of Napster — all people are thieves — much more than the true lesson, that there's a huge business in selling downloadable songs for a modest price. As a result, neither service actually sells songs for downloading; they merely rent them.

The services sell monthly subscriptions that allow you to listen to songs without downloading, a function called streaming. Or, subscribers can download crippled versions of songs that, in most cases, can't be burned onto a CD or transferred to a portable device. These downloaded songs contain digital time bombs that make them unplayable after a certain period of time, or once you stop paying the subscription fee.

As for one-stop shopping, forget it. Each service only has songs from certain labels, and neither even has all the artists and songs it claims. Big artists, like the Beatles, Madonna and the Dave Matthews band, aren't on either service because their contracts require special permission.

So what are the new services like? MusicNet (www.musicnet.com), which offers songs from Warner Music, BMG, EMI and others, is a bewildering, stunted affair. It has one subscription plan — $9.95 a month for 100 streams and 100 crippled downloads. After 30 days, the down-

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No Olympic Games on Web video - yet

By Anick Jesdanun
Associated Press

NEW YORK — Perhaps you want to catch a replay of a breathtaking downhill run or missed the misstep that cost a promising figure skater the gold.

You won't find Olympic events on the Internet during the Winter Games that start this week. You'll have to settle for photos online.

Again, the International Olympic Committee is restricting audio and video footage online.

That means no live or delayed coverage of competition, no highlights and no interviews with athletes in Olympic venues.

It all comes down to figuring out the proper place for the Internet in a world dominated by television, which pays hefty sums for broadcast rights. Until that balance is struck, the IOC is simply saying, "no."

For the hometown Salt Lake Tribune, the restriction means offering multimedia presentations using text, music and still photos.

For the British Broadcasting Corp., it means interviewing its TV correspondents and fans — or grabbing athletes outside the official venues.

For the FeedRoom, which repackages local newscasts from around the United States for Internet broadcast, it means trimming the sportscast.

"You cringe as an online video destination," said Jon Klein, FeedRoom's chief executive. "You wish you could supply them, yet you sit on your hands and wait."

Two months after the 2000 Summer Games in Sydney, Australia, the IOC convened a special meeting in Lausanne, Switzerland, bringing together industry leaders from new media and old. But little was resolved and objections remain.

Michael Payne, the IOC's marketing director, said Olympics coverage may be routine online in the future, but today the Internet pales compared with television. He said the Internet audience is much smaller, and Internet companies have yet to come up with a proven business model.

Gary Zenkel, NBC's executive vice president for the Olympics coverage, said the global nature of the Internet

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ASSOCIATED PRESS

Manny Mellor of the Salt Lake Tribune says the newspaper's Web site will have plenty on the Olympics, although it won't be able to include any video of the Games themselves.

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